

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 1

The Silk Road

A Calm Journey Across Ancient Asia

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the first envoy to the rediscovered library cave, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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The heart of the road

At the centre of the routes lay the Taklamakan Desert, ringed by the Tian Shan, the Pamirs and the Kunlun. Caravans went around it, along northern and southern chains of oasis towns, and met at Kashgar before the passes west.



Oasis towns and sites plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Rivers and coastlines are modern. Routes shifted over the centuries, so none are drawn as fixed lines.

Places you'll visit in the episode

Chang'an: the Han and Tang capital, near modern Xi'an, where Zhang Qian set out about 138 BCE.

Mogao Caves: cut into a cliff near Dunhuang from 366; 492 painted caves survive.

Kucha: an oasis kingdom known for music, orchards and monasteries, home of Kumarajiva.

Kashgar: where the northern and southern routes around the desert meet before the passes west.

Suyab: a trading city near Tokmok, later one of the Tang Four Garrisons, from 679.

The Jade Gate: Yumen, the western gate of the Han watchtower line near Dunhuang, built of rammed earth.

Turfan: an oasis below sea level, watered by underground karez channels, many still flowing.

Khotan: the jade kingdom, its stone gathered from rivers coming down from the Kunlun.

Issyk-Kul: the "warm lake" of the Tian Shan, which Xuanzang described and which rarely freezes.

Samarkand: Sogdian city, later Timur's capital, with the Registan and Ulugh Beg's observatory.

TWO THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

A timeline of the road



Silk itself is far older than the road: fabric from Yangshao-culture burials in China is more than 5,000 years old.

c. 4th–3rd c. BCE
A felt saddle cloth with a panel of Chinese silk is buried at Pazyryk, in the Altai mountains.

c. 138 BCE
Emperor Wu sends Zhang Qian west to seek the Yuezhi as allies.

c. 119 BCE
Zhang Qian's second mission goes to the Wusun; missions and trade follow.

c. 104–101 BCE
A Han campaign to Fergana brings back the "heavenly horses".

97 CE
Gan Ying reaches a "great sea" and turns back on the sailors' warnings.

166
Travellers claiming to come from Daqin, the Roman world, arrive by sea.

c. 313
Sogdian letters, among them Miwnay's, are lost in a mailbag west of Dunhuang.

366
The first cave at Mogao is begun, by tradition.

401
Kumarajiva is brought to Chang'an, where he translates Buddhist texts.

629–645
Xuanzang travels to India by the Tian Shan and returns with 657 texts.

751
A Tang army is defeated at Talas; in 755 the An Lushan rebellion begins.

762
Al-Mansur founds Baghdad, the Round City, on the Tigris.

868
The Dunhuang Diamond Sutra is printed, the oldest dated printed book.

1253–1254
William of Rubruck reaches the court of Möngke near Karakorum.

1271–1295
Marco Polo's journey to the court of Kublai and back.

1325
Ibn Battuta sets out on some 24 years of travel.

1338–1339
Gravestones in the Chüy Valley record a sudden pestilence.

1370
Timur makes Samarkand his capital.

1420s
Ulugh Beg builds his observatory and star catalogue.

1405–1433 · 1498
Zheng He's voyages; Vasco da Gama reaches India by sea.

1877
Ferdinand von Richthofen popularises the name "Silk Road".

1900
Wang Yuanlu finds the Library Cave at Mogao; Sven Hedin finds Loulan.

Four empires along one road



Approximate extent of the four great powers around 100 CE, when goods could pass from Han China to the Roman world through Parthian and Kushan lands. Borders are simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset and moved often. Later places from the episode (Baghdad, Karakorum, Quanzhou) are shown for reference.

People you'll meet

Zhang Qian: Han envoy, held by the Xiongnu for about ten years, who reached Fergana and came home.

Kanishka: Kushan king and great patron of Buddhism; his dates are debated.

Miwnay: a Sogdian woman left in Dunhuang with her daughter, whose letters survive.

Al-Khwarizmi: scholar from Khwarazm whose name gave us "algorithm".

Al-Biruni: born in Khwarazm in 973; measured the earth and wrote a book on India.

Ibn Battuta: traveller from Tangier who crossed from Saray to Bukhara and Samarkand.

Gan Ying: sent west in 97 CE by Ban Chao; he turned back at the "great sea".

Kumarajiva: monk of Kucha who translated the Lotus and Diamond Sutras in Chang'an.

Xuanzang: monk who crossed the Tian Shan in 629 and returned from India in 645.

Ibn Sina: born near Bukhara in 980; physician who studied in the Samanid library.

Marco Polo: Venetian who travelled to Kublai's court and returned in 1295.

Ulugh Beg: Timur's grandson, ruler and astronomer of Samarkand.

Legend or history?

Some of the road's best-loved stories are legends or rest on a single source: Leizu and the cocoon in her tea, the princess who hid silkworm eggs in her headdress, the monks who smuggled eggs to Justinian in a hollow cane, and the story that papermaking spread west from prisoners taken at Talas. The episode marks these clearly apart from what the documents and archaeology show.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Learn more





Artistic impressions of the Registan in Samarkand and of Issyk-Kul at dawn, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

Books

The Silk Road: A New History ↗, Valerie Hansen (Oxford University Press, 2012).

The Silk Roads: A New History of the World ↗, Peter Frankopan (Vintage, 2017).

Life Along the Silk Road ↗, Susan Whitfield (University of California Press, 2nd ed., 2015).

The Silk Road: A Very Short Introduction ↗, James A. Millward (Oxford University Press, 2013).

The Silk Road in World History ↗, Xinru Liu (Oxford University Press, 2010).

The Travels of Marco Polo ↗, trans. Ronald Latham (Penguin Classics).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

Museums & places

British Museum, London: Stein's finds from Dunhuang, including the Silk Princess panel.

International Dunhuang Programme: the Library Cave manuscripts, reunited online.

Penn Museum, Philadelphia: Asian and Middle Eastern galleries.

Along the road: the Mogao Caves, Samarkand's Registan, and the Burana Tower and Tash Rabat in Kyrgyzstan.

Podcasts

In Our Time: The Silk Road, BBC Radio 4, with Frances Wood, Tim Barrett and Naomi Standen.

"Let the road fade now, the camels slow, the lamp grow low. You have nowhere to be, and nothing left to carry."

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